

Sharif secure amid Kashmiri unrest

送信者: EG South Asia 受信日時: 2026-08-15 03:55

【メール原文】

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Pakistan

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Sharif government will weather Kashmiri protests amid fragmented provincial unrest

14 Aug 2026 14:50 EDT [Discover more on the Portal](#)

Short-term trajectory:

Long-term trajectory:

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Pakistani security forces have violently suppressed Kashmiri protests and suspended local assembly elections, the latest episode of ethnic unrest across border provinces that remains too fragmented to threaten Islamabad.

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The expressions of support for the Kashmiris by the junior partner of Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif's government, the Pakistan People's Party (PPP), are largely rhetorical and do not pose a risk to the Sharif government's stability.

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The crackdown is embarrassing given Pakistan's accusations about India's suppression of its Kashmiri population, but any international fallout will be limited as Islamabad takes on an expanded diplomatic role in the Iran conflict.

The unrest in Pakistan-administered Kashmir poses no serious threat to the Sharif government. Violent protests in Azad Jammu and Kashmir have led to the suspension of voting in the last seven constituencies of the assembly elections. A local civil society body, the Joint Awami Action Committee, claims 50 people were killed. Pakistani authorities have only admitted that seven security personnel have died. Though the death toll appears unusually high, the underlying dynamic—local grievances, a rigged political structure, and demographic displacement—has been building for years without threatening Islamabad's control.

Pakistani Kashmir has experienced sporadic protests over the past few years. Ethnic Kashmiris have been reduced to about a quarter of the region's population thanks to emigration from other parts of Pakistan. Although the region is notionally a self-governing entity, Kashmiris believe the structure of the assembly, in which only 33 of the 53 seats are elected locally, is designed to ensure Islamabad remains in charge. The present round of protests began in June but peaked during the assembly elections in late July and early August. The Pakistani government and the military keep tight control over Kashmir because of its centrality to the long-running dispute with India.

Still, the crackdown undermines Islamabad's claims about India's oppression of Kashmiris. The protests and killings are a bad look for both Sharif's government and Field Marshal Asim Munir, the country's de facto military ruler (see: Military control of judiciary will further complicate revenue targets , 25 November 2025). Pakistan portrays New Delhi as an occupier of the Indian-controlled side of Kashmir and claims that all Kashmiris would prefer to live under Pakistani rule. The fact that Kashmiris are facing suppression and state violence in Pakistan undermines this argument. The government has sought to limit information on the unrest—after the international press began to reveal the scale of the protests, authorities imposed severe restrictions on foreign journalists.

The PPP's verbal support for the Kashmiris does not affect the stability of the Sharif government. Even with voting in the last seven constituencies on hold, Sharif's ruling Pakistan Muslim League (PML-N) is projected to win the local assembly elections, having already secured 25 of 53 seats because of the large emigrant population. Though the Sharif government's coalition partner, the PPP led by Bilawal Bhutto, has rhetorically taken up the Kashmiri cause, the move is opportunistic. As the non-Kashmiri majority in the territory largely votes for the PML-N, Bhutto is trying to make inroads among Kashmiri voters and chip away at Sharif's military backing in the hope that the generals may eventually put him in charge.

Broader ethnic unrest remains too fragmented to threaten Islamabad. Kashmiris are too marginal a population to compel the government to change its policies. That said, Pakistan is facing ethnic unrest in all of its border provinces; over 430 security personnel have been killed in insurgencies in Khyber Pakhtunkhwa and Balochistan in the first seven months of the year. While there are some shared economic concerns, such as high youth unemployment, there is little else connecting the disparate local demonstrations.

Yet other than the insurgency in Balochistan (see: Military will struggle to contain escalating insurgency in Balochistan , 6 February 2026), the ethnic protest movements are too small and fragmented to represent a threat to Islamabad. Munir is politically secure thanks to his role in raising Pakistan's diplomatic profile through mediation efforts in the Iran war, as well as the military's ability to fight India to a draw last May.

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